

Discover Windows Sideshow

Use a second display to view a range of information, from mail to weather forecasts

By far one of the least-known components of Vista is Windows Sideshow. This handy tool can be used in conjunction with compatible devices to display all manner of information on a secondary screen or mobile device. From notebook PCs with a main screen and a smaller secondary display, to mobile phones, a wide range of devices can be used to keep up to date when away from your computer.

Through the use of 'Gadgets', supplementary displays can be used to view information from websites and programs without the need to use your computer in the usual way. These mini programs can display information from your email client, draw the latest news from the internet and much more. Here, we show you how to get started with this obscure, yet deceptively powerful, tool.

Step 1

The number of devices that support the Windows Vista Sideshow feature is increasing, but currently Sideshow is mainly found on notebook computers. Sideshow-compatible devices, such as the Asus W5Fe (<http://uk.asus.com>), look like an ordinary portable PC, complete with keyboard and standard screen. But when the notebook is closed, an additional smaller screen can be found on the lid. This auxiliary display can be powered whether the laptop is switched on, powered down, or in sleep mode. As the contents of the screen can be viewed even when the computer is not switched on, it is possible to keep up to date with important information, without wasting precious battery power. For example, the contents of your email inbox is at your fingertips without needing to boot into Windows.



Step 2

Sideshow is not limited to notebook computers. There are a variety of devices that offer support in one form or another. Devices such as remote controls and digital photo frames, such as the I-mate Momento (www.momento.live.com), can display Sideshow Gadgets, which are essentially mini applications. The number and range of gadgets available means that devices that previously had a single function – such as controlling a television or displaying digital photos – can be extended into much more useful tools. A compatible TV remote can be used to check emails while watching the television, while a digital photo frame can display not only images, but also the weather forecast or instant messaging conversations. With so many Gadgets to choose from, there is virtually no limit to what can be achieved.



Step 3

A piece of beta software from Microsoft can also be used to bring the power of Sideshow wirelessly to Pocket PCs and smartphones running Windows Mobile 5 or 6. To connect a device of this type using Sideshow, your computer must have Bluetooth capability and your mobile device needs to have .NET Compact Framework 2.0 9 (www.tinyurl.com/rmje9) installed. To download the Sideshow for Windows Mobile tool, visit www.tinyurl.com/4t936h and click the Download button. Save the executable file to the desktop and once the download is complete, double-click it to start the installation.



Step 4

The installer will offer to extract the files to a folder of your choice. Once extracted, connect your Windows Mobile device to the computer using a USB cable and select the option to browse the device. If .NET Compact

